Bill's Helix Cheat Sheet / Command Reference

1 Introduction

- Document version: 1.0.0-beta, April-2026
- Based on Helix version: 25.07.1.
- Distributed at:
  https://github.com/wrwetzel/Helix-Cheat-Sheet
  https://helix.wrwetzel.com
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1.1 Definitions

- **file** - the actual data on storage device
- **buffers** - data from one or more files loaded into memory
- **view** - one or more visual areas on screen showing one or more buffers
- **workspace** - the directory from which Helix was launched
- **under selection** - the entire word containing the cursor, not just the selection
- **alternate buffer** - the previous active buffer
- **textual line** - text as defined by the newline character
- **visual line** - what appears on screen after word-wrapping

1.2 Typographic Conventions

- **`word`** - alphanumeric, punctuation-delimited
- **`WORD`** - whitespace-delimited
- **`Ctrl-c`** - Ctrl and c key pressed simultaneous.
- **`Alt-c`** - Alt and c key pressed simultaneous.
- Some Alt and Ctrl characters may conflict with terminal capture and require terminal configuration change.
- **`␣c`** is space followed by the character c.
- Metavars **`<regex>`**, **`<file>`** and **`<ch>`** represent user input. The angle-brackets are not part of the input.
- **`␣`**, **`<minus>`**, and **`<under>`** used for clarity. **`<enter>`**, **`<del>`**, **`<bksp>`**, etc. used for non-printing control characters.
- Commands are separated from definitions by a dash. Synonyms are separated by commas. Related commands are separated by slashes. The separators are never part of the command though commands may include a dash, comma, or slash.

1.3 Launching

- **`helix`**
- **`helix`** `<file>`
- **`helix`** `<file1> <file2> … <filen>`
- **`helix`** `–help`
- **`hx`** `in some distributions or by alias`

1.4 Basics

Editing paradigm: select first, action second. *mode* and *count* are optional.

```
[mode][count][select][command]
```

1.4.1 Example

```
v3wd
        v – enter select mode
        3 – select 3
        w – words
        d – delete
```

1.4.2 Samples

```
       wd – delete word
       xc – change line
       %y – yank entire file
```

1.5 Modes

As used in Helix documentation.

```
        : – command
        i – insert
        v – select or extend
        z – view - change view preserving
            selection
        g – goto
        m – match
   Ctrl-w – window
        ␣ – space
     [, ] – unimpaired
```

2 Primary Commands

2.1 Essentials

`u / U`	undo / redo change in linear history
`Alt-u / Alt-U`	move backward / forward in tree history
`:ear / :lat`	move backward / forward in history by step count or time span (1s, 2m, 3h, 4d)
`<nn><cmd>`	repeat <cmd> <nn> times
`Esc`	return to normal mode

2.1.1 Quit

Add **!** suffix to force operation.

`:wq`	write current buffer and quit
`:wq <file>`	write current buffer to <file> and quit
`:wqa`	write all buffer(s) and quit
`:q`	quit current buffer, exits if last

2.1.2 Files

`:o <file>`	open <file> in new buffer
`:w <file>`	write current buffer to <file>
`:hs <file>`	open/create <file> in new horizontal split
`:vs <file>`	open/create <file> in new vertical split
`␣wf`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in horizontal split
`␣wF`	open/create file(s) under selection(s) in vertical split
`gf`	open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection.
`␣f`	open file picker at LSP workspace root
`␣F`	open file picker at current working directory
`␣g`	open changed file picker

2.1.2.1 File Picker

All pickers, here and elsewhere, are *fuzzy* - they tolerate gaps in the input, ranking closer matches higher.

`<enter>`	open selected in current view
`Ctrl-s`	open selected in new horizontal split
`Ctrl-v`	open selected in new vertical split

2.1.3 Buffers

Add **!** suffix to force operation. Buffers named by file they contain.

`:n`	create new scratch buffer
`:bc`	close current buffer
`:bca`	close all buffers
`:bco`	close all but current buffer
`:bn`	next buffer
`␣b`	open buffer picker
`ga`	go to last accessed/alternate buffer
`gm`	go to last modified/alternate buffer
`gn`	go to next buffer
`gp`	go to previous buffer

2.1.4 Views

Ctrl-w and `␣w` are synonymous.

`␣ws / ␣wv`	split horizontal / vertical, current buffer
`␣wns / ␣wnv`	split horizontal / vertical, new buffer
`␣wq`	close current split
`␣wo`	close all but current split
`␣ww`	next split
`␣wh/j/k/l`	move to buffer left / up / down / right
`␣wH/J/K/L`	swap split with buffer on left / up / down / right
`␣wt`	transpose split

2.1.4.1 View Movement

Commands shown with **z** prefix. The prefix is not used in sticky mode, which is a view-only navigation mode appropriate for browsing a file without editing.

`Z`	enter sticky mode, exit with Esc
`zz, zc`	align to center
`zt`	align to top
`zb`	align to bottom
`zm`	align to middle horizontally
`zj`	scroll down
`zk`	scroll up

2.1.5 Help

`:tutor`	open tutorial
`␣?`	open command palette

2.2 Movement

2.2.1 Cursor Movement

Normal Mode: motion replaces selection
Select Mode: motion extends selection

```
h/j/k/l – left / up / down / right
 gh, g| – beginning of line
 <nn>g| – column <nn>
     gl – end of line
     gg – top of file
  <nn>G,– line <nn>
 g<nn>g
     ge – bottom of file
     gw – two-char labels on words, label to
          go to word
     g.– to last modification in current file
     gj – down textual line
     gk – up textual line
     gs – first non-white-space char
     gt – top of screen
     gc – middle of screen
     gb – bottom of screen
```

2.2.2 By Language Server Protocol - Semantics

Requires LSP support.

```
 gd – go to definition
 gy – go to type definition
 gr – go to references
 gi – go to implementation
 ]d – next diagnostic
 [d – prior diagnostic
 ]D – last diagnostic
 [D – first diagnostic
```

2.2.3 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
 ]f, [f – to next, prior function
 ]t, [t – to next, prior type definition
 ]T, [T – to next, prior test
 ]a, [a – to next, prior arg
 ]c, [c – to next, prior comment
 ]g, [g – to next, prior change
 ]G, [G – to last, first change
 Alt-e – move to end of parent node in
         syntax tree
 Alt-b – move to start of parent node in
         syntax tree
```

2.2.4 By Page

```
 Ctrl-b – page up
 Ctrl-f – page down
 Ctrl-u – half page up
 Ctrl-d – half page down
```

2.3 Selection

Selection: a range of characters between anchor and cursor
Normal Mode: move and select
Select Mode: move and extend selection

2.3.1 Operations

```
     % – select whole file
 Alt-; – swap anchor and cursor
 Alt-: – selection to normal direction (cursor
         at end)
 Alt-o – expand selection syntax-aware
 Alt-i – shrink selection
     ; – collapse selection(s) to cursor(s)
```

2.3.2 By TextObjects

```
 ma<ch> / – match around / inside the
   mi<ch>   object indicated by <ch> below:
     w / W – word / WORD
         p – paragraph
 (, [, ', etc.– specified surround pairs
         m –  closest surround pair
         f – function
         t – type or class
         a – argument/parameter
         c – comment
         T – test
         g – change git hunk
```

2.3.3 By Syntactic Objects

```
 w / W – to start of next word / WORD
 e / E – to end of current word / WORD
 b / B – to start of current word / WORD
     x – current line, extend by line
     X – extend to line
 Alt-x – shrink to line bounds
    ]p – to next paragraph
    [p – to prior paragraph
```

2.3.4 By Treesitter - Syntax

Requires Treesitter support.

```
 Alt-o – expand selection to parent syntax
         node
 Alt-i – shrink syntax tree object selection
 Alt-p – select previous sibling node in
         syntax tree
 Alt-n – select next sibling node in syntax
         tree
 Alt-a – select all sibling nodes in syntax tree
 Alt-I – select all children nodes in syntax
         tree
```

2.3.5 By Character Value

Lower case: forward
Upper case: backward

`f<ch>, F<ch>`	to <ch> inclusive (find)
`t<ch>, T<ch>`	to <ch> exclusive (till)
`Alt-.`	repeat last find / till

2.4 Select Mode

Movement: extends selection
Search: adds to selection

`v`	toggle select mode
`Esc`	return to normal
`)`	cycle primary selection forward
`(`	cycle primary selection backward
`Alt-,`	remove primary selection

2.5 Multiple Selections

Multiple independent cursors / selections, one is *primary*.

2.5.1 Creating

Create multiple selections from selection.

`s<regex>`	matches become selections
`S`	split on match
`Alt-s`	split on newlines
`C, Alt-C`	add selection below, above

2.5.2 Operations

`&`	align on primary cursor
`Alt-<minus>`	merge selections
`Alt-<under>`	merge consecutive selections
`,`	remove all except primary selection
`Alt-,`	remove primary selection
`( / )`	rotate primary backwards / forwards
`Alt-( / Alt-)`	rotate content backward / forward
`K`	keep selections matching the regex
`Alt-K`	remove selections matching the regex

2.6 Alter Buffer Content

2.6.1 Insert

`i`	before selection
`a`	after selection
`I`	at start of line
`A`	at end of line
`o`	add line and insert below cursor
`O`	add line and insert above cursor
`Esc`	end insert (return to normal)
`.`	repeat last insert

2.6.2 Add

`]␣`	newline below
`[␣`	newline above
`ms<ch>`	add delim <ch> around selection

2.6.3 Delete

`d`	selection -> yank buf, delete selection
`Alt-d`	delete, no save
`md<ch>`	delete delim <ch> around selection

2.6.4 Change

`c`	selection -> yank buf, change selection
`Alt-c`	change, no save
`=`	format by LSP
`mr<ch1><ch2>`	replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>

2.6.5 Indent Lines

`>`	Indent line(s) containing selection
`<`	Undent line(s) containing selection

2.6.6 Change Case

Change case of all letters in selection

`~`	change case
`` ` ``	set lowercase
`Alt-` `	set uppercase

2.6.7 Comments

All apply to selection.

`␣c, Ctrl-c`	Toggle comment
`␣C`	Toggle block comment
`␣Alt-C`	Toggle line comment

2.6.8 Increment / Decrement

`Ctrl-a`	increment the selected number
`Ctrl-x`	decrement the selected number

2.6.9 Miscellaneous

`J`	join lines in a selection
`Alt-J`	join lines inside selection and select the inserted space
`<under>`	trim whitespace from selection

2.7 Copy / Paste / Replace

```
y – selection -> yank buf
p – paste yank buf after the cursor
P – paste yank buf before the cursor
␣y – yank selection(s) -> system clipboard
␣Y – yank main selection -> system
     clipboard
␣p / ␣P – paste clipboard after / before
          selections(s)
␣R – replace selection(s) with clipboard
r<ch> – replace selection with <ch>
R – replace selection with yank buf
" – select register to yank to or paste
    from
```

2.8 Search

```
/<regex> – search forward for regex
?<regex> – search backward for regex
n, N – next, previous match
* – search for current selection, respect
    word boundaries
Alt-* – search for current selection
```

2.9 Registers

Identified by single char <ch>

```
"<ch> – change to reg <ch>
"<ch>y – yank into reg <ch>
"<ch>p – paste from reg <ch>
"<ch>R – replace with reg <ch>
```

2.10 Macros

```
"<ch>Q – toggle capture to reg <ch>, default @
"<ch>q – play macro in reg <ch>, default @
```

2.11 Jumplists

```
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist
␣j – open jumplist picker
```

2.12 Match Mode

With regard to balanced delimiters.

```
mm – go to matching delim
mi<ch> – match inside delim <ch>
ma<ch> – match around delim <ch>
ms<ch> – add delim <ch> around
         selection
md<ch> – delete delim <ch> around
         selection
mr<ch1><ch2> – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2>
```

2.13 Shell

All commands pipe each selection to shell command.

```
| – replace selection(s) with output
Alt-| – ignore output
! – insert output before each
    selection(s)
Alt-! – append output after each
        selection(s)
$ – keep selection(s) where command
    returned 0
```

2.14 Approaching an IDE

```
␣G – debug - experimental
␣k – show documentation for item under
     cursor
␣s – open document symbol picker
␣S – open workspace symbol picker
␣d – open document diagnostics picker
␣D – open workspace diagnostics picker
␣r – rename symbol
␣a – apply code action
␣h – select symbol references for symbol
     under cursor
```

2.15 Editor Configuration

```
:config-open – open the config file
:config-open-workspace – open the workspace
                         config file
:config-reload – reload the config file
```

2.16 Miscellaneous

```
␣' – open last picker
␣/ – open global search in workspace
     folder picker
```

3 Commands in Specific Contexts

3.1 Insert Mode Editing

Navigation keys shown.

`Ctrl-s`	commit undo checkpoint
`Ctrl-x`	autocomplete
`Ctrl-r`	insert a register content
`Ctrl-w, Alt-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Alt-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`Ctrl-h, <bksp>, Shift-<bksp>`	delete previous char
`Ctrl-d, <del>`	delete next char
`Ctrl-j, <enter>`	insert new line
`<Up> <Down> <Left> <Right> <PageUp> <PageDown> <Home> <End>`	usual meaning but discouraged

3.2 Command Line Editing

`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close prompt
`<enter>`	open selected
`<tab>`	select next completion item
`<backtab>`	select previous completion item
`Alt-b`	backward a word
`Ctrl-b`	backward a char
`Alt-f`	forward a word
`Ctrl-f`	forward a char
`Ctrl-e`	to prompt end
`Ctrl-a`	to prompt start
`Ctrl-w, Ctrl-<bksp>`	delete previous word
`Alt-d, Ctrl-<del>`	delete next word
`Ctrl-u`	delete to start of line
`Ctrl-k`	delete to end of line
`<bksp>, Ctrl-h`	delete previous char
`<del>, Ctrl-d`	delete next char
`Ctrl-s`	insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later)
`Ctrl-p`	select previous history
`Ctrl-n`	select next history
`Ctrl-r`	insert the content of the register selected by following input char

3.3 Pickers

Navigation keys shown.

`Shift-<tab>, Ctrl-p, <Up>`	previous entry
`<tab>, Ctrl-n, <Down>`	next entry
`<Home>`	to first entry
`<End>`	to last entry
`Ctrl-u, <PageUp>`	page up
`Ctrl-d, <PageDown>`	page down
`<enter>`	open selected
`Alt-<enter>`	open selected in the background without closing the picker
`Ctrl-s`	open horizontally
`Ctrl-v`	open vertically
`Ctrl-t`	toggle preview
`Esc, Ctrl-c`	close picker

3.4 Popups

Displays documentation for item under cursor.

`Ctrl-u`	scroll up
`Ctrl-d`	scroll down

3.5 Completion Menu

Displays documentation for the selected completion item. Any other keypresses result in the completion being accepted.

`Shift-Tab, Ctrl-p`	previous entry
`Tab, Ctrl-n`	next entry
`<enter>`	close menu and accept completion
`Ctrl-c`	close menu and reject completion

3.6 Signature-help Popup

Displays the signature of the selected completion item.

`Alt-p`	previous signature
`Alt-n`	next signature

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Ctrl-h – delete previous char (3.1)
Ctrl-h – delete previous char (3.2)
Ctrl-i – move forward in jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-j – insert new line (3.1)
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line (3.1)
Ctrl-k – delete to end of line (3.2)
Ctrl-n – next entry (3.3)
Ctrl-n – next entry (3.5)
Ctrl-n – select next history (3.2)
Ctrl-o – move backwards in jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-p – previous entry (3.3)
Ctrl-p – previous entry (3.5)
Ctrl-p – select previous history (3.2)
Ctrl-r – insert a register content (3.1)
Ctrl-r – insert the content of the register selected by following input char (3.2)
Ctrl-s – commit undo checkpoint (3.1)
Ctrl-s – insert a word under doc cursor (may be changed to Ctrl-r Ctrl-w later) (3.2)
Ctrl-s – open horizontally (3.3)
Ctrl-s – open selected in new horizontal split (2.1.2.1)
Ctrl-s – save current position to jumplist (2.11)
Ctrl-t – toggle preview (3.3)
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line (3.1)
Ctrl-u – delete to start of line (3.2)
Ctrl-u – half page up (2.2.4)
Ctrl-u – page up (3.3)
Ctrl-u – scroll up (3.4)
Ctrl-v – open selected in new vertical split (2.1.2.1)
Ctrl-v – open vertically (3.3)
Ctrl-w – delete previous word (3.1)
Ctrl-w – delete previous word (3.2)
Ctrl-x – autocomplete (3.1)
Ctrl-x – decrement the selected number (2.6.8)
Esc – close picker (3.3)
Esc – close prompt (3.2)
Esc – end insert (return to normal) (2.6.1)
Esc – return to normal (2.4)
Esc – return to normal mode (2.1)
F<ch> – to <ch> inclusive (find) (2.3.5)
I – at start of line (2.6.1)
J – join lines in a selection (2.6.9)
K – keep selections matching the regex (2.5.2)
N – next, previous match (2.8)
O – add line and insert above cursor (2.6.1)
P – paste yank buf before the cursor (2.7)
R – replace selection with yank buf (2.7)
S – split on match (2.5.1)
Shift-<bksp> – delete previous char (3.1)
Shift-<tab> – previous entry (3.3)
Shift-Tab – previous entry (3.5)
T – test (2.3.2)
T<ch> – to <ch> exclusive (till) (2.3.5)
Tab – next entry (3.5)
X – extend to line (2.3.3)
Z – enter sticky mode, exit with Esc (2.1.4.1)
[␣ – newline above (2.6.2)
[– specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
[D – first diagnostic (2.2.2)
[G – to last, first change (2.2.3)
[T – to next, prior test (2.2.3)
[a – to next, prior arg (2.2.3)
[c – to next, prior comment (2.2.3)
[d – prior diagnostic (2.2.2)

- **[f** – to next, prior function (2.2.3)
- **[g** – to next, prior change (2.2.3)
- **[p** – to prior paragraph (2.3.3)
- **[t** – to next, prior type definition (2.2.3)
- **]␣** – newline below (2.6.2)
- **]D** – last diagnostic (2.2.2)
- **]G** – to last, first change (2.2.3)
- **]T** – to next, prior test (2.2.3)
- **]a** – to next, prior arg (2.2.3)
- **]c** – to next, prior comment (2.2.3)
- **]d** – next diagnostic (2.2.2)
- **]f** – to next, prior function (2.2.3)
- **]g** – to next, prior change (2.2.3)
- **]p** – to next paragraph (2.3.3)
- **]t** – to next, prior type definition (2.2.3)
- **`** – set lowercase (2.6.6)
- **a** – after selection (2.6.1)
- **a** – argument/parameter (2.3.2)
- **b / B** – to start of current word / WORD (2.3.3)
- **c** – comment (2.3.2)
- **c** – selection -> yank buf, change selection (2.6.4)
- **d** – selection -> yank buf, delete selection (2.6.3)
- **e / E** – to end of current word / WORD (2.3.3)
- **etc.** – specified surround pairs (2.3.2)
- **f** – function (2.3.2)
- **f<ch>** – to <ch> inclusive (find) (2.3.5)
- **g** – change git hunk (2.3.2)
- **g.** – to last modification in current file (2.2.1)
- **g<nn>g** – line <nn> (2.2.1)
- **ga** – go to last accessed/alternate buffer (2.1.3)
- **gb** – bottom of screen (2.2.1)
- **gc** – middle of screen (2.2.1)
- **gd** – go to definition (2.2.2)
- **ge** – bottom of file (2.2.1)
- **gf** – open/create file(s) under selection, open url under selection. (2.1.2)
- **gg** – top of file (2.2.1)
- **gh** – beginning of line (2.2.1)
- **gi** – go to implementation (2.2.2)
- **gj** – down textual line (2.2.1)
- **gk** – up textual line (2.2.1)
- **gl** – end of line (2.2.1)
- **gm** – go to last modified/alternate buffer (2.1.3)
- **gn** – go to next buffer (2.1.3)
- **gp** – go to previous buffer (2.1.3)
- **gr** – go to references (2.2.2)
- **gs** – first non-white-space char (2.2.1)
- **gt** – top of screen (2.2.1)
- **gw** – two-char labels on words, label to go to word (2.2.1)
- **gy** – go to type definition (2.2.2)
- **g|** – beginning of line (2.2.1)
- **h/j/k/l** – left / up / down / right (2.2.1)
- **i** – before selection (2.6.1)
- **m** – closest surround pair (2.3.2)
- **ma<ch>** – match around delim <ch> (2.12)
- **ma<ch> / mi<ch>** – match around / inside the object indicated by <ch> below: (2.3.2)
- **md<ch>** – delete delim <ch> around selection (2.12)
- **md<ch>** – delete delim <ch> around selection (2.6.3)
- **mi<ch>** – match inside delim <ch> (2.12)
- **mm** – go to matching delim (2.12)
- **mr<ch1><ch2>** – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> (2.12)
- **mr<ch1><ch2>** – replace delim <ch1> with <ch2> (2.6.4)
- **ms<ch>** – add delim <ch> around selection (2.12)
- **ms<ch>** – add delim <ch> around selection (2.6.2)
- **n** – next, previous match (2.8)
- **o** – add line and insert below cursor (2.6.1)
- **p** – paragraph (2.3.2)
- **p** – paste yank buf after the cursor (2.7)
- **r<ch>** – replace selection with <ch> (2.7)
- **s<regex>** – matches become selections (2.5.1)
- **t** – type or class (2.3.2)
- **t<ch>** – to <ch> exclusive (till) (2.3.5)
- **u / U** – undo / redo change in linear history (2.1)
- **v** – toggle select mode (2.4)
- **w / W** – to start of next word / WORD (2.3.3)
- **w / W** – word / WORD (2.3.2)
- **x** – current line, extend by line (2.3.3)
- **y** – selection -> yank buf (2.7)
- **zb** – align to bottom (2.1.4.1)
- **zc** – align to center (2.1.4.1)
- **zj** – scroll down (2.1.4.1)
- **zk** – scroll up (2.1.4.1)
- **zm** – align to middle horizontally (2.1.4.1)
- **zt** – align to top (2.1.4.1)
- **zz** – align to center (2.1.4.1)
- **|** – replace selection(s) with output (2.13)
- **~** – change case (2.6.6)